

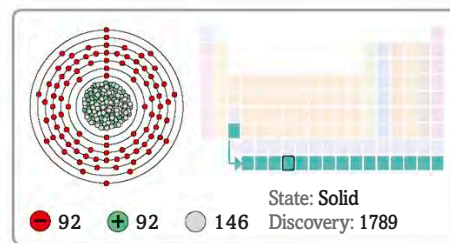
92

U

Uranium

Named after the planet Uranus, uranium was the first known radioactive element. In the early 20th century, some manufacturers used uranium in **glass bowl** glazes, only to realize later that it was a harmful metal.

An unstable form, called uranium-235, is used as fuel in nuclear reactors and in atomic bombs.



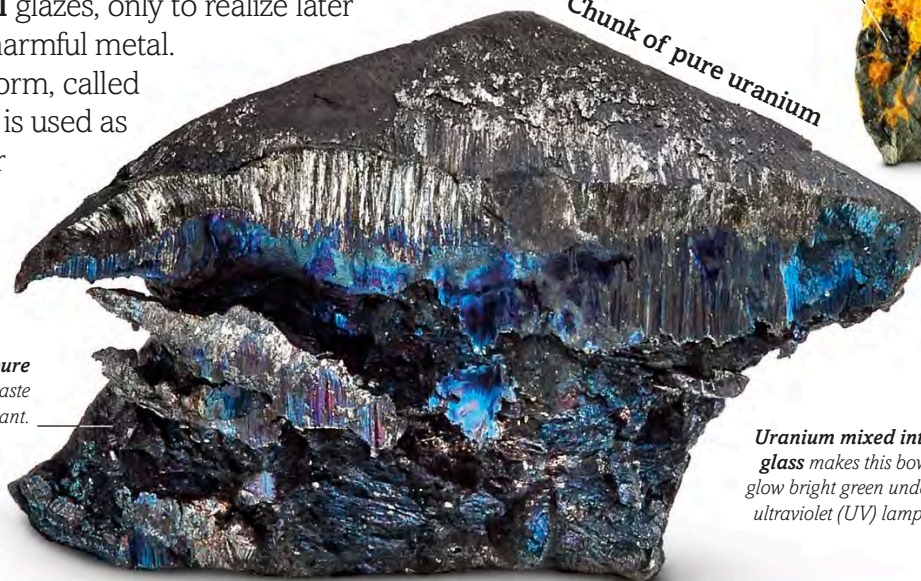
These black sections contain uranium dioxide, which is the main source of uranium.

Chunk of pure uranium



Uraninite

This sample of pure uranium is waste from a nuclear plant.



Uranium mixed into glass makes this bowl glow bright green under ultraviolet (UV) lamps.



Glass bowl

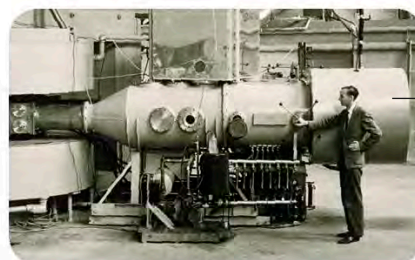
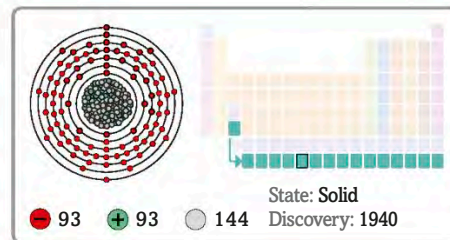
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Np

Neptunium

The radioactive elements in this mineral decay to form neptunium.

Uraninite



This cyclotron, built in 1938, was used to discover neptunium.

Cyclotron at the University of California, Berkeley, USA

Sitting next to uranium in the periodic table, neptunium was named after the planet Neptune. It exists in small amounts in radioactive ores, such as aeschynite. It forms during nuclear explosions and was first identified inside a machine called a **cyclotron**. There are no known uses for neptunium.